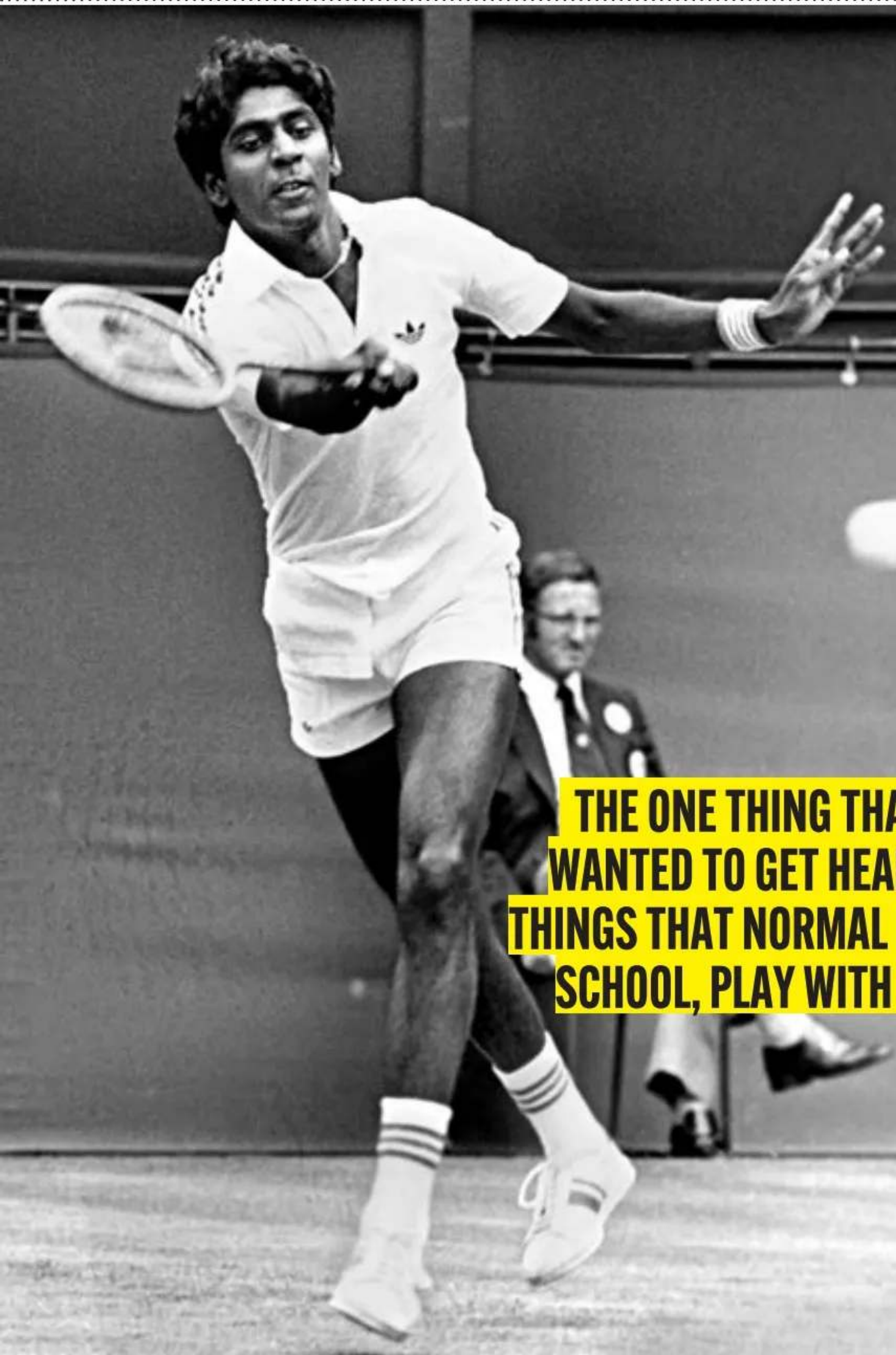




Sepia-tinted in memory: Vijay Amritraj competing against the defending champion, Bjorn Borg of Sweden, in the men's singles second round match at Wimbledon, in London, on June 26, 1979. GETTY IMAGES

would do — go to school, play with friends, fly kites, and all of that. But it was interesting to see what drove my parents, especially my mother. They could have decided, 'Listen, let's make him good enough to just go to school, pass his exam, and eventually get a job'. But that wasn't the case. They wanted to also not leave me behind because Anand [Amritraj], the older boy, was healthy, first in class, and he won the junior [tennis] championships pretty early. So, they didn't want me to be

THE ONE THING THAT DROVE ME WAS THAT I WANTED TO GET HEALTHY ENOUGH TO DO THE THINGS THAT NORMAL KIDS WOULD DO — GO TO SCHOOL, PLAY WITH FRIENDS, AND FLY KITES

teach me in the hospital. It was a great challenge for my parents. Let me put it this way: I always told them, 'If you didn't have me, you would have thought parenting was easy.' The aspect of a dream came through only after I started to believe that I could win. I won my first tournament as a schoolboy at 13 and a half, and then I won the National Championships, beating [Ramanathan] Krishnan in the final

(1972). Those were two landmark matches that made me believe. One year later, I was in the top-10 at 19, beating [Rod] Laver and [Jimmy] Connors. So, it all rapidly came about.

What drove you to be the player you were and the person you are?

The one thing that drove me was that I wanted to get healthy enough to do the things that normal kids

left behind.

And as talent or luck would have it, I won the Nationals and the Asian Championships and reached the quarterfinals at Wimbledon and then the US Open back-to-back (1973). I ended up beating Laver at the [U.S.] Open, which put India firmly on the global tennis map. That was the big one in the Open Era (1968 onwards). This also made the West believe I was a force to be reckoned with. I did reach four quarterfinals at the Grand Slams, two at Wimbledon, and two at the [U.S.] Open. I made two Davis Cup finals; the only occasions India has been there in the Open Era. All these things mattered a lot to me.

The other hats you have donned... like helming the Vijay Amritraj Foundation (VAF), the Britannia